Searching Arrays

Earlier in the chapter, we look at ways to process all the elements of array by iterating them with loops. Sometimes your program might only need to work with a sub-set of elements, or maybe just one. You might not know in advance where in the array a particular element can be found, or you might only want to test if a particular value exists. PHP offers a range of functions to make these tasks simple.

Test Value Exists

Iterating through an array and testing each value until the required one is found isn't a particularly onerous task. If you've read through the entire chapter so far you have all the tools needed to achieve this. However, PHP provides a built-in function which gets the job done in one line:

```
$arr = ['Alice', 'Bob', 'Russell'];

if (in_array('Russell', $arr)) {
    print "I found a Russell!\n";
}

Output:
I found a Russell!
```

`in_array()` takes two arguments: the value you want to find and the array to be searched. It returns `true` if the value is found, `false` if not. Note that strings are case sensitive and types will be coerced. A stricter search (where value and type are tested) can be enabled by adding a third boolean parameter: `in_array($val, $array, true)`. Note that `in_array()` does not search recursively, it will only search the first dimension of multidimensional array.

Test Key Exists

If you need to test for particular key rather than value then `array_key_exists()` works in much the same way as `in_array()`: